

LFB HOLDINGS

Decision Distortion Assessment Reports

BASE REPORT

Your Decision Distortion Assessment — Accumulation Is Your Dominant Force

Your assessment is in. Of the four forces that bend organizational judgment under pressure, accumulation is showing up most actively in your company right now. It's the quietest of the four forces — and typically the last one an organization recognizes in itself, because every individual decision that produced it looked reasonable when it was made.

Of the four forces — noise, bias, accumulation, and incentive misalignment — accumulation is the only one that operates across decisions rather than within them. Noise distorts individual judgment calls. Bias bends the direction of individual calls. Incentives govern how fast either compounds. Accumulation is different: no single decision has to go wrong for it to take hold. What it requires is simply that addition keeps winning over subtraction, decision after decision, until the aggregate weight of individually-defensible choices has made the next decision harder than it needs to be.

What accumulation is

Accumulation is what happens when organizations have a deeply ingrained, largely invisible default toward addition — adding features, processes, hires, metrics, and strategic priorities when faced with a problem — while systematically overlooking subtraction as an equally valid path forward.

This isn't a preference. It's a cognitive accessibility failure: additive options come to mind first, readily and automatically. Subtractive options require deliberate generation, and under pressure, deliberate generation is exactly what's in short supply. The pull operates at three reinforcing levels. Cognitively, addition is simply more accessible — it surfaces first. Culturally, accumulation looks like action; subtraction leaves no visible trace. And economically, the incentive structures of venture-backed companies reward what gets built and launched, not what gets wisely stopped or removed.

Each individual addition — a feature, a process, a hire — seems reasonable in isolation. The problem only becomes visible in aggregate. And by the time it does, the aggregate has made the next decision harder: more variables, more stakeholders, more weight resisting clarity.

How it typically shows up

Facing a new competitor, a Series C company launches two new product modules, attacks both enterprise and SMB simultaneously, and spins up four parallel pilots. The KPI dashboard swells to fifteen metrics. Decision rights blur. Coordination meetings triple while capital spreads thin. From outside, it looks like scaling execution issues. From inside, every one of those decisions felt justified — the modules addressed real gaps, the market expansion was based on real signals, the pilots were tracking real opportunities. What none of those individual decisions accounted for was what all of them together had created: a company that had outrun its own ability to steer.

The hardest part of accumulation is that no single decision was wrong. The aggregate was the problem. And the aggregate was invisible until the speed dropped and the burn rose.

Where your assessment is pointing most clearly within accumulation is on aggregate visibility — specifically, the absence of a regular practice of looking at what all current commitments together have created. The question your assessment flagged names the central mechanism of accumulation: no individual decision was wrong; the aggregate was the problem, and it was only visible in retrospect. Most organizations evaluate decisions one at a time, which is how accumulation hides. The product decision looked right. The hire looked right. The new market looked right. The strategic priority looked right. The question that didn't get asked was what all of them together meant for the organization's ability to operate with clarity and speed. Building that aggregate review into the rhythm of the company — not as a crisis response but as a standing practice — is the primary structural protection against accumulation becoming unsteerable before anyone notices it has.

Where to start

The first intervention is a standing aggregate review on a fixed schedule. Once a quarter, before any new commitments are made, map everything the organization is currently carrying — every active initiative, every open hiring plan, every strategic priority, every metric being tracked. Not to evaluate each one individually. To look at what all of them together have created and ask whether the organization could execute that portfolio with clarity and speed if it had to today. The review isn't a cutting exercise. It's a visibility exercise. Accumulation compounds in the dark; the review turns the light on.

The second is a portfolio question built into every significant addition. Before any new initiative, hire, or strategic priority is approved, the room asks one question: what does this add to the total weight of what we are already carrying, and are we confident we can carry it without slowing down what already matters most? This doesn't require a formal process. It requires one question asked consistently, before the commitment is made rather than after the weight is already on the organization's back.

The research behind this

The academic foundation for what your assessment detected comes primarily from Subtract: The Untapped Science of Less by Leidy Klotz — the most direct account of addition default and why subtractive options systematically fail to surface when organizations are under pressure to improve. The finding that's most directly applicable to your situation: even when adding and subtracting require identical effort, people still overwhelmingly default to addition. The default isn't about convenience. It's cognitive, cultural, and economic simultaneously — which is why it takes a structural intervention to counteract it.

What's next

The full Decision Distortion whitepaper from LFB Holdings walks through how accumulation combines with the other three forces — noise, bias, and incentive misalignment — and how to locate the specific points in your decision process where a single closed gap would have the greatest effect.

If you'd like to talk through what your results mean for your company specifically, we're glad to do that.

LFB Holdings: lfbholdings.com

For ongoing case-by-case analysis of how these forces operate in real organizational decisions, Bad Call is a subscription brief that applies this framework to actual decision sequences — company autopsies, one at a time.

Bad Call: badcall.ai